

Think Piece 3

The question I would like to raise in response to our last readings is: *In a social environment where technology is constantly evolving and changing ways we think and act, how do we determine the difference between which aspects of ethical thought must adapt to change, and which can remain unchanged?* I arrived at this question as both Bynum's and Vallor's readings were both mainly regarding rethinking the ethics of human nature through a unique framework that was recently created in response to new technological advancements. In Bynum's piece, this framework is Norbert Wiener's Information Ethics, and in Vallor's it is the 12 Technomoral Virtues. As Bynum explains, it is very common for major scientific/technological innovations to have equally major social/ethical effects, like how the invention of the printing press made mass spreading knowledge much easier and more efficient and greatly accelerated ethical discourse. With Artificial Intelligence on the rise changing how we think, philosophers are once again rethinking the nature of human beings and society. What can we consider ethical in a world where all decisions are made by computers? Wiener foresaw this issue nearly a century ago with his rising field of cybernetics: "input and output need not be in the form of numbers or diagrams but might very well be, respectively, the readings of artificial sense organs" (Wiener, 1948, pg. 36). This precise issue is why he founded the concept of Information Ethics. At its core, Information Ethics is a 4-step process of thinking that ensures human thought will remain critical, morally sound, and unhindered by artificial thought: "1. Gather information about the external world, 2. Derive logical conclusions from that information, 3. Decide what to do, and then 4. Carry out the decision" (Bynum, 2008 pg. 9). Obviously, as technology becomes more and more advanced and grows capable of doing countless more things, it is foolish to think it will not take up some of these tasks. Wiener said this himself all the way back in 1950, with a catch: "That we shall have to change many details of our mode of life in the face of the new machines is certain; but these machines are secondary in all matters of value [when compared to humans]" (Wiener, 1950, pg. 2). I believe this is a very important factor in determining how we alter our ethics in correspondence to new innovations: That human thought must always remain primary and unimpeded. Vallor's piece of "Technomoral Wisdom" follows this idea very well, as in it she looks at many traditional virtues and adapts them in new ways to apply to "emerging technomoral advancements" (Vallor, 2016, 119). In total, Vallor looks at 12 virtues in this way. A couple of these stood out to me as especially important and related to the previous reading. The first of these was the second technomoral virtue, Self-Control. Vallor defines self-control here as "An exemplary ability in technosocial contexts to choose, and ideally to desire for their own sake, those goods and experiences that most contribute to contemporary and future human flourishing." (Vallor, 2016, 124) Human flourishing is a common goal in many of these virtues, as well as another aspect that I believe must be very important in how we adapt our ethical thinking as more advancements are made. Another virtue that stood out to me was the tenth virtue, flexibility. This is something that may not be commonly seen as a virtue, but Vallor defines it as "A reliable and skillful disposition to modulate action, belief, and feeling as called for by novel, unpredictable, frustrating, or unstable technosocial conditions." (Vallor, 2016, 145). This makes sense - now more than ever, the speed at which we are advancing is extremely rapid and unpredictable, and we need to be open to unfamiliar things as a result. Vallor says this is all but required to "cope with acute technosocial opacity" (Vallor, 2016, 145), or the challenges of predicting societal impacts of new technologies. This is a very interesting concept that I have not heard of until now, but is a very real issue that we must try to circumvent in our ways of ethical thinking.